9

His thumbnail dragged across his lower lip. Back and forth, back and forth…the sensation at once soothing yet lost on him. He was too busy thinking, tooling, considering and reconsidering his options–their likelihood, his gut reaction to their outcome–to feel anything else right now.

There has to be a way, he reiterated.

He'd come up here, convinced he'd figured it out and unable to go back to sleep until he tried. Four attempts tonight, four runs, and his thought about shifting the power distribution harder into the auxiliary engines instead of the primary thrusters had proven futile. They'd help him be more agile, sure, in ways that let him fly with slightly more flair, but it had cost him too much in acceleration. His time scores expressed no improvement. So here he sat again, pulled back from the runs, as 4 twirled and spun before him. *There has to be a way*.

In his defense, he had tried for a while there to just swallow what Rho had told him. Be happy with what you have. Make the best of this. But only weeks had passed before those words got washed out by what rang so much louder in his head. Excellence mattered. Testing himself–and passing–mattered. What other people thought of him? Nice, yeah, but he'd gotten so good at ignoring what people had to say of him negatively that he found it hard to care what they thought when he did well. *He* determined that. *He* had his expectations for himself, *he* set his standard, and *he* held himself up for measure. This complacency thing? That was not him. There had to be a way.

He perked up at movement in his peripheral vision, his intuition catching the approaching ship a beat or two faster than his sensors. He sat up ever so slightly, scrutinizing the oncomer thoroughly, then relaxed back as he marked the craft–a battered ZH-40–as no one in particular. Their intent, too, was clear, as the ship slowed upon approaching the practice run. There it hovered, its

engines simmering. Then another long bit of it sitting there.

Han frowned, a mix of curiosity and concern causing him to automatically make a reach toward the autopilot. Then a familiar chime rang in, and he relaxed with a grim chuckle. *Scan away*, he allowed with a pant. *I ain't interested in you.*

The oncomers' unease assuaged, the ship's engines fired on, and then in a sweep, she darted forward. She crossed the barrier in a blink, but Han had already prepped his own clock to measure the time, and his thumb pressed down at just the right moment. Then he froze, focused, studying each movement of the craft, anticipating how she might traverse the field. She sped up and around a hull piece, as she should, then dipped under the same crawler arm he'd passed weeks before. Coming up on a cluster of old crates, she had an opportunity perhaps to duck through them, but instead banked and went around, and Han internally snickered and called them a coward. He watched the time, though, curious if they'd still beat the maximum even with the maneuver. Some part of him wanted them not to.

He narrowed his eyes, watching how they handled their inertia—stiff on the turns, too reliant on thrusters to course-correct. They tracked ahead but weren't reading the debris flow in real time, missing a tight gap between two slabs and veering wide instead. Yellow-bellied, he accused again, watching as the time ticked by, each second spent lagging a second too many for the Pit. Han smirked, already writing them off—until, at the last second, they snapped into a lateral roll and slipped clean through a bulkhead's blind spot.

His smirk faded–he hadn't expected that. His thumb felt numb as it clicked the timer off just as the ZH crossed the other barrier. 2:57.

His lips puckered up big as he read the time again. *Not fair*, he groused, tired as much as frustrated, then dropped the timer back behind him. Not fair that he was good–he *knew* he was–but couldn't prove it. Languidly, his attention turned back to the practice run–the ZH that had swung back around to the start to fly it again–and Han admitted he'd lost his drive for the night. The answer would come to

him eventually, he felt–randomly on some trip, he'd stumble into something that would leave him mad he'd not thought of it earlier, and it would work.

His hands moved to shut off the autopilot, to take the ship back under his control so she could return to her berth. He swung away from the Practice Runs, pushing out into the inky Black and toward the mottled brown moon before him. For the first time that evening, fatigue pulled at him, and he readjusted himself in his seat to make sure he stayed awake. Just a little bit longer, he calculated…another hour or so to touch down, walk back to the apartment, and then he could settle, crawl into his bed, knock out. Maybe in doing so, he'd sleep away the dull pain in his chest.

The sudden chime of the ship's comm startled him, but a chagrin quickly molded his mien. Chewie, he surmised. The Wook was upset at him for disappearing in the middle of the night, either afraid he'd run off or concerned that Han wouldn't be back in time to leave for the trip they had scheduled. For a second, he considered not answering it, to let the call ring and let the Wook wonder, but something else urged him to not be so opaque. Unhurried, he accepted the call.

"Han, you up there?"

Rho, he recognized, and Han sat up in his seat again, gawking at the blinking comm light. Frozen for a beat, he then scrambled to turn on two-way. "Yeah, Rho, it's me. What's up–what's the matter?"

The answer came delayed, either because Rho didn't know what to say or knew what to say and regretting having to. "I need help," the Old Man answered gravely. "I'm…I'm in over my head."

The prickling of flesh started all over Han's body, everywhere at the same time. This tone, this seriousness…he'd never heard Rho talk like this before. "Wh-what is it?"

"It's…I don't even know what to say. I don't know what I'm looking at."

"Well, where are you?"

"The Chance Castle," Rho answered in a tired exhale. "D'you

think you could come by?"

Han gulped first, thinking–or, trying to think, but the thoughts came too fast to make sense of them. He heard himself answer, though. "Yeah. Yeah—I'm just coming back down. I'll be right there."

One hand went to drop the call and then in the same motion gave a boost to his sublight engines. *Hurry*, he felt in his bones, the tightening of his muscles at an intuitive understanding that time was suddenly fleeting. In flashing, near incoherent calculations, he plotted his next steps: land at the Hutt Palace–that would be the easiest and fastest way to get him to the Chance Castle, a Hutt-owned casino in the Entertainment District. Catch the tram and get off at the Promenade stop. Figure the rest out from there.

He tripped then on the details of the situation: Rho, at a casino and in need of help–*his* help–in the middle of the night? He scrambled to make that make sense, but none of the pieces fit together. Rho could be an early riser, but it was still a few hours before daybreak, and he was an old man who went to bed early and didn't stay out late carousing. At a casino, but Rho didn't gamble. Far as Han knew, he never went up to the Entertainment District. So…*what* then?!

Landing went smoothly, and he came racing out from the hangar of the Hutt Palace to sprint across the open plaza toward the closest tram station. Shapes shifted in the dark at his approach, figures upset and staring at the lone man running like his life depending on it but with no immediate pursuer. Han only noticed them in the back of his mind, his attention focused on examining the tram station as he approached, discerning how many people stood at the platform as a prediction of how soon–or long–the next tram may arrive. It looked deserted, though, and he didn't know what to make of that–the usual kind of traffic for this hour or a sign that the tram had already come and gone?

He slowed to a jog then a stop as he came closer, panting hard as he squinted again into the night, then saw a figure move into the

just-too-far darkness. “Tram come recently?” he asked, gulping in air behind the words.

The person turned at his voice, assessed him, shrinking. “Just left.”

“Fuck,” Han snapped under his breath, then spun around, recalculating, eyes scoping what he could see in the sloping light of the street lamps, least those that were operational. He sputtered, unsure, then spotted his remedy: a simple little jumpspeeder, probably belonging to some kid, tipped up against the side of a metal barrier. He ran to it and pulled, felt the bike snag on something, then spotted the glint of metal wrapped through the open gap in the front chassis. He pulled the bike away again, in one smooth motion whipping out his pistol and shooting away the lock, then used the butt of the gun to smash at the central wiring console. The plasticrete cracked under the third blow, and he wedged his fingers in and pulled off the cover, exposing the wires. Reholstering his blaster, he grabbed at his pocket knife and made quick work of stripping the wires and hotstarting the engine. It hummed to life, yet somewhere in the back of his brain, he scoffed at how weak the engine sounded. Hardly the roar he’d known of a swoop. But he had no time to entertain his dismay, and threw a leg onto the seat and kicked off to help the bike get started.

It took fifteen frustrating minutes to finally arrive at the beginning of the Promenade, the central portion of the Entertainment District. Sourly, Han questioned if the jumpspeeder really was the faster choice, but since he hadn’t heard the clamor of the tram yet, it must have been. As the road widened into the open square, he slowed it to a corner and abandoned the bike beside a shuttered shop. He’d jog the rest of the way; not only would that be faster, but he hadn’t been up here but once and wasn’t quite sure where exactly the Castle was located.

Luckily, the blue-grey of dawn had started, and he scrutinized the buildings that lined the Promenade’s central square and curved at its end. It seemed mostly like it was the bright lights of crusted over casinos, whose open entrances and attempt at grandeur obscured the

other quieter business fronts, some of them deserted, some of them sleeping, and many of them in some half-alive state, the scraggling hangings-on of a sorry enterprise. He skimmed the marquees at his right, recognizing some of the names but not spotting the one he needed, then looked down the lane at the storefronts marking the Promenade's edge, and read nothing helpful either. Momentarily, his attention pivoted to a trio of people moving through the night in that swaying motion that meant too much of something, then he reared back in revulsion to watch one of them double over and puke into the square's fountain of squalid, standing water, its edged line in a sickly orange algae. In turning away, he finally took in the sign in front of him–huge and sweeping across the wide entrance–that in flashing lights spelled out 'Chance Castle.'

The lobby made him queasy in a different way–the immediate shock of noise and lights and perfume that competed sickeningly with the stink of the Smuggler's Moon made his eyes spin and his stomach turn. He realized only then that he had no idea exactly *where* Rho was–only that he was somewhere in the complex–and lifted his chin to try and read the directional signage hanging above the security desk.

"Solo?" a foreign voice questioned.

Han startled to hear his name, and dropped his chin to take in the Twi'lek in security uniform who stood about three long paces from him, staring in anticipation.

Han's jaw clenched, an automatic brace. "Yeah?"

The guard made a smooth pivot on the ball of his foot, wordlessly throwing a hand over his shoulder as he did so to beckon Han to follow.

Again, that nervous tightening pulled at his diaphragm, and Han gulped down his apprehension to obey.

They cut through the casino, then walked through a camouflaged door that opened into dark, labyrinthine halls. They passed different offices and storerooms, many of them closed off but occasionally occupied by moneycounters, accountants, and a single

janitor who did her utmost to keep her head down and mind her business as the Twi'lek and the human passed. Eventually, they came to a room with the door open, and the Twi'lek dispassionately gestured again at him to enter.

Han glanced the guard over again, read how apathetic he seemed to the whole thing, then leaned forward on a toe to peer into the room beyond the threshold. Immediately, he picked out Rho, sitting behind a table, his head propped up in his hand in weary distress, but not looking hurt or even threatened. In front of him sat some hologram display that he was half-considering. Han took another tiptoe forward and saw more bodies in the room–a person to Rho's left, sitting at the table, and behind them some kind of team that hung near the walls. Han looked closer, picked out the other seated guest as a Zisian, older, with a substantial scar from his hairline down across the left of his green face to his chin that left him one-eyed. The Zisian spotted him; they met eyes. Han's brow furrowed in half-recognition, that strange sense of knowing a face but unable to place exactly where from.

"Come in, Captain Solo," another voice insisted, one he *did* recognize in its smoky timber, and Han leaned past the doorway to take in the headdress and square jaw of Deino, a retinue of Palace guards flanking her.

Han damn near choked on his uvula at sight of Deino. Whatever was happening…it was big.

"Han?" Rho questioned, lifting his eyes to take in the shadow in the doorway, his angst melting for a second into relief. "It's all right, c'mon," the Old Man beckoned.

At the reassurance, Han stiffly joined Rho at the table. His eyes swept both sides of the room first, finding discomfort at the intensity of the attention, until his gaze settled back on the Old Man.

"Well. How do I get started?" Rho paused, sighed, slightly pushed himself back into his seat as he thought. "D'you know anything about Hutt Space politics?"

"Anything about recent history?" Deino clarified.

Han gawked at her first, then turned back to Rho. "Maybe. I don't know…tell me what you think I'm missing."

Again, the Old Man heaved a sigh. "You probably know this much, but Hutt Space has operated as independent for hundreds of years. No major galactic power, not even the Republic, touched these borders. They certainly never made the mistake of *threatening* them."

"Threat?" Han questioned, strained.

"We arranged a truce, however uneasy, with previous administrations," Deino picked up. "The Imperials, however, doesn't seem to understand the playbook."

Han tensed at mention of the Empire, his thoughts running away ahead of him.

"They came here three years ago," Deino continued. "Some commander gunning for a Moff position came to Nar Shaddaa posturing. We called his bluff and arranged an understanding. Now, unfortunately, the Empire feels more confident in their position, and apparently are rethinking the agreement."

"Do you see now," the Zisian hissed, "how shortsighted it was for *kajidic* Desilijic to arrange that deal without the remaining Hutt factions? The terms were too flimsy to guarantee autonomy for long."

"As you've stated *many* times already," Deino cut back icily.

"So they're in talks now?" Han probed, ignoring the stranger on his right.

"Past talks," Deino interjected, her jaw tight. "Things are escalating and quickly."

His stomach lurched. The Empire did not dawdle…that was evident in their training as much as their track record. They always meant to keep momentum: so much harder to pick up the pace again. Better to march forward, to assault, to keep the enemy on their toes. Keep them confused, scrambling, keep them questioning where to put resources, people, leadership. Don't allow them time to organize and counterstrike. Keep them uncomfortable. "In chaos lies victory."

Rho pushed the holo display in Han's direction, catching his attention again. "I need you to read this," the Old Man entreated. "I need you to tell me what this means."

Astonied, Han's fingers managed to grip the display and bring it toward him. He realized right away that he was staring at text. Words. Then his eyes squinted, reading. "Suppression." "SFS outfit, awaiting delivery." "Arakyd concussion magazines." His brain started whirling, not unable to read it but unable to believe it. He sputtered, doubting, and then, as though to taunt him, his focus suddenly picked out the faint six-spoked roundel behind the words.

Wide eyed, he snapped his neck up to Deino. "How the fuck did you get this?!"

Her lips tightened over the truth. "That's irrelevant."

"Irrelevant?!" Han barked back. "You've got Imperial battle plans, and it's *irrelevant*?!"

"They're going to invade?!" the Zisian shrieked.

"That's what we need Han here to tell us," Rho interceded, his hands hovering over the table in an effort to deescalate. He gestured at Han, urging him to continue. "I called you to read it. You know how to piece through this stuff."

Han scoffed, sitting straightbacked in his chair. "Me? Well…" He coughed, as much at a loss as he was eager to put space between him and entanglement. "Why didn't you ask Mako?!"

Rho's open face hardened down into tight lines across his brow. His voice came out in a growl. A correction. "Because I don't *trust* Mako." And then, as quickly as it appeared, the snarl evaporated. "Please."

It took more than a few breaths to process what Rho had asked of him, more still to realize he had no choice other than to obey. With a faulty attempt at quelling the tremor in his breath, he settled his attention again on the holo display. "I haven't looked at anything like this since the Academy," he mumbled as he perused the details, trying to orient himself. "This kind of documentation was reserved for the admirals and their first officers."

"Just tell me what you can," Rho pressed.

Han skimmed the preamble on the opening page, the usual wordy, bureaucratic hogwash all these reports got slathered in, and then skipped down to the lower portion, eyeballing for some kind of a confirmation or objective. Sure enough, there it was, written in fairly plain language: NAR SHADDAA. BATTLEGROUP OBSIDIAN. The date: eight weeks from now.

No, he thought as his chest sank, and then he read further, anxious to know the specifics. Underneath the preamble and the header, a description of the outfit that made up Battlegroup Obsidian: as the capital ship, a Praetor was first in the listing. Then four Neb Bs, followed by six Gozantis–standard, not assault carriers.

Han's brow furrowed, prompting questioning from the table. He gestured at the display, reading back to them the outfit of ships as he frowned. "There's not enough here for an invasion force or even a significant battle."

"But it would be enough to hijack the hyperspace entrance," Rho cut in. "Make it difficult for anyone to either get in or out of Nar Shaddaa. Cut off trade."

At that, the room went quiet, but the silence was loud. Trade was the Smuggler's Moon heart and soul. The Imps would have the Hutts by the balls…or would, if they had them.

"We can't let that happen," Deino cut in definitively. Not suggesting, but ordering. Her gaze landed hard on Rho, who seemed to feel its weight, as he didn't lift his head.

"Is the Praetor coming fully equipped?" someone behind the Zisian asked.

Han turned into the direction of the voice, facing a figure shrouded in darkness. He couldn't help a dry laugh at the question. "They don't keep 'em fully equipped. Haven't in a long time."

"Double check," the Zisian ordered curtly.

Suppressing a grunt, Han switched to a second tab that would list the specifics of each ship. He read hurriedly, his brain somehow remembering how to decipher all the jargon and acronyms to make

sense of the report. The Imperials, as always, were thorough, and he read what he anticipated: the ship was a hot mess. For weapons systems, the quad turbo lasers were in serious need of an overhaul; a third of the myriad types of ion cannons were off-line; and of the eight tractor beams between her port and starboard side, only three remained operational. Mechanical systems, too, were struggling: her hyperdrive alone had a maintenance list damn near as long as his leg. Additional systems–defense, communications, life supports–were down or struggling. She did not have nearly the crew she once had–half, in fact of what she'd probably carried in her heyday.

He frowned to read it over, then read it over again, confounded. The Empire didn't waste ships, but they didn't send half-hearted forces, either. Not unless they had something to gain regardless of the outcome.

He must have been wearing his confusion plainly on his face, as Deino called out to him again, questioning his assessment.

"This capital ship is in drastic need of repairs. I don't even understand why they're sending her on a mission."

"She's crippled?" Deino tried to clarify.

"Basically. I mean, it's not like all her cannons are busted, but she's a shadow of what she was."

"Why send a depleted capital ship?" she asked of the group.

"Better question is," Rho waxed, "why bother with the show of force at all and not send a Star Destroyer?"

Han studied the read-out a beat longer, mulling the mystery himself. Finally, he cocked his head. "They must be convinced they don't have to. They kept the Praetors in service to handle low conflict areas."

"They think the Hutts will fold," Rho answered. He picked his head up and met eyes first with Han, then turned to Deino with resolve. "I don't fold," he insisted through a tight jaw.

"Rho," Han spat out, "no. An old biddy like a Praetor or not, they'd slap you outta the sky."

"There must be a resistance," the Zisian declared in that same cold, dry manner as Deino. An order, not a suggestion.

Han balked, leaning toward the green-skinned humanoid. "*Resistance?* From you and what navy?!"

The Zisian gawked at him a moment, surprised at the Corellian's boldness, but then a smile crept onto his face, a sinister, uncomfortable grin that made Han sit back slightly in his seat. "No, Captain Solo– *you* and what navy."

"What?!" he hollered. "Fuck that!"

"Han!" Rho snapped, his brow furrowed with a mix of disappointed and upset.

"No, fuck this," he announced, then planted hands on the table to help himself stand up.

He didn't even raise his butt all the way out of his chair. A grip found his shoulder, forced him back down, then held him there firmly. He twisted in his seat, keen to see his aggressor, then slowed when he identified it was a Cosian.

His eyes squinted, remembering. Not just a Cosian–well, not just *any* Cosian. He recognized that scowl, could see it in his mind's eye lasering him from the doorway of Booth Four…

"Let's rewind a little bit," the Zisian crooned, coming to his feet and planting his hands wide on the table so he could lean forward. "About six years. Little operation nearby, just down the Shag Pabol." He leaned forward even more, his one eye almost winking it squinted so hard in pleasure. "Do you remember, Captain Solo? Or, should I say, 'Pilot Draygo?'"

Han's eyes bulged with recollection. The glitterstim factories on Ylesia…owned by *kajidic* Besadii. The majordomo to High Priest Teroenza who ran the facility had been a Zisian.

He gulped, understanding now who was in front of him, why he'd had that nagging sense of knowing him but not: he'd shot the majordomo in the face as part of his escape. The blaster wound marred him enough to make him difficult to recognize. Besides, he'd believed the smug fuck was dead.

The hairs across his body, from his forearms down to his calves, all stood on end, painfully reaching out in some shock-stricken stress. Somewhere deep in his subconscious, he understood exactly where this conversation was headed.

"Wait!" Rho interjected. He pointed at the Zisian. "Who the fuck *are* you?! Do you know Han?"

"Apologies, Captain Metis, to have to delay my introduction. I am Ganar Tos, majordomo to His Excellency, Aruk the Hutt."

"Aruk?!" Han spat out in shock. "Teroenza dead?"

Tos' lips pursed. "Hardly. After your exit, I was awarded with a sizable promotion."

Rho had already spun to Deino, incredulous. "You all are working with the Besadii?!"

She lifted her chin. "Sometimes, cooperation matters more than competition."

The room was silent for a beat–Han and Ganar glowering at each other, Deino holding her reaction, Rho taking time to search the face of each person at the table for clarity–until the Old Man slammed his palms down on the table. "Okay," he spat out, "what the fuck is going on?!"

Ganar gave a quick shoulder-hitch of excitement. "Oh, interesting," he lilted. "You don't know about Captain Solo's past?"

Rho stared hard at Han first before he turned back to the majordomo. "Enlighten me."

Ganar snorted first. "Solo here worked for the Besadii six years ago. He was trusted, in faithful service, until he lost his head. He trespassed, stole from our Treasure Room, assaulted me, killed a number of other guards, stole one of our vessels and kidnapped one of our pilgrims–"

"Fuck you," Han cut in, fuming. "Bria wasn't a 'pilgrim.' You slime lured her there–lured all those people–"

"They came of their own accord," Tos shot back. "We offered them sanctuary–"

"You *brainwashed* them!" Han returned, beginning to rise from his seat again.

"Sit!" Deino ordered, her voice cutting through the bravado as her retinue behind her stepped forward to enforce the command.

Once the room settled, Deino lifted her eyes to her Besadii counterpart. "Ganar Tos, I'd like to conference outside."

The Zisian inclined his head in respect, then waited his turn to file out of the room. He did so, head erect, though not without flashing a glare at Han one last time.

Han bristled at the leer, then watched out of the corner of his eye as the pompous shit left. Relief arrived first, to be free of the presence of both majordomos and their retinue, though as he settled back into his seat, his eyes met the fuming stare of the Old Man.

"*Han*–"

He put hands up. "Don't be mad."

"Don't be *mad*?!" Rho bellowed. "You have a record with the Besadii?!"

Han helplessly shrugged. "I–"

"Stole from them? Assaulted them?" Rho seethed. "Don't tell me you have an outstanding bounty."

Han shrugged a shoulder. "I thought they'd forgotten about i–"

"*Forgotten about it!*"

Han panted, grasped at what he could. "I thought you said you didn't care! That everybody's got something in their closet!"

"Not when it comes to the Hutts!" Rho roared. "Dammit, Han! For the love of *fuck*, do you know what you could have done to me?!"

At his outburst, the Old Man crouched in his seat, his brow set in a heavy scowl that he leveled at Han, so much so that the younger man slouched, face flushed, in a feeble attempt to hide.

A few long breaths, though, seemed to ease the scorn, though it did not evaporate entirely. "And what the fuck was all that about brainwashing?"

Han sucked in a big breath, remembering–fleetingly–the design of Ylesia's glitterstim factory complex, the "pilgrims" who worked it, the t'landa Til High Priests who conducted the "religious" Exaltation. The way Bria had gawked at him and cried when he'd finally gotten her to understand it was all bullshit. They'd be here all day if he tried to explain everything to Rho…and he felt time slipping from his fingers the longer he sat there. "It's–the Besadii have something strange. It's fucked up."

The answer seemed to cool the Old Man. In silence, he receded into his thoughts.

Han, meanwhile, pricked his ear toward the hallway. He could hear murmuring but nothing definitive. The knot in his stomach was telling, though: this did not bode well for him. Whatever they were discussing out there, he needed the fuck out.

"I should have seen this," Rho groaned, his hand rubbing hard into his eyes. "They're so bold. They don't give a fuck."

Han wilted to see the Old Man so distressed. "They're doing it because it's outrageous. Shock and awe. It works."

"Review the material again," Rho insisted suddenly, weary again but insistent. "Tell me everything you think I need to know."

"To do what?" Han questioned.

"To do something about this!"

"Rho," Han breathed, sympathetic but critical. "This isn't small."

Rho's lips folded into themselves in thought. In doubt. "How many do you think we'd need?"

Weakly, Han sighed in frustration. Yet Rho looked at him so intently…he'd have to give him some kind of answer. "Comfortably," he started, "I'd say you'd need at least a hundred medium-sized ships. If you could get your hands on a cruiser, that'd be even better, because that Praetor is weak, but no pushover. Something will have to be out there and take the bulk of the beating." He cocked his head. "You know anyone with a cruiser?"

"I don't," the Old Man answered plainly. "Do you?"

Surprised at the dry humor, Han snorted a half-laugh. "Not personally." He shifted his weight around, thinking. The only person he *knew of* who had something like that was Renthal. He remembered, then, seeing her force skirting out in the distance a few weeks before, hovering in the shadows. Like sharks.

"Why don't they hire people?" Han criticized, more out loud than at Rho, but the Old Man nodded his head in thought.

"Cheap," Rho offered curtly, then his brows raised in reluctant concession. "And hired guns are tricky prospects. Turrets can always turn around." Rho dragged a hand over his face. "A hundred is…a lot. I know that's why they asked me. They figured I could drum up whatever they needed."

Han frowned at the Old Man's woe. How crushed he looked. "Can't you?"

At that, Rho sighed, long and painfully. His head fell into a cupped hand. "Just–tell me again what we'd be up against."

Sullen, Han set his jaw and reviewed the data packet again. For the first few minutes, it felt like he was simply going through the motions. He must have switched between the same screens six or seven times, mindlessly flickering through tables and maintenance lists and crew stats for each of the vessels. He felt glazed. No, drunk? No, he had more sense than that. Was this what being drugged felt like?

No, he registered somewhere in the still acute back of his head. This was shock.

Leadership–he suddenly thought; it might matter to know who would be commanding. He resumed his task, intentional now, navigating his way back over to the preamble, eyes darting for the delineation. Finally, he found it: Greenlax. *Moff* Llohmin Greenlax.

Once more, he winced at the strangeness–why send a moff on a mission like this?! He bit at the inside of his cheek, thinking, then admitted to himself he was never quite great at following the politics of *why* the military got deployed against whom and the self-promotion inherent to the internal workings of Central Command. But he knew

someone who did. He'd have to be stealthy about asking him after Rho had growled about keeping him out, but Han knew enough about Mako to know his eyes would be good in this. The younger Spince had seemingly not inherited any of his father's more noble traits–Senator Gregnor Spince believed in order and decorum and duty–but the old man was sharp as a tack, and Mako could be, too. In fact, he might know all the commanding officers–the Spinces kept dirt on everybody.

He skimmed back up and switched over to the Praetor sublisting, looking again for a *military* commander. Locating it, he read the name, then blinked. Read it again, unbelieving, feeling his blood run cold.

The Navy was huge. Surely, there was more than one Commodore Sfilas. It couldn't be–

His eyes darted back, scanning, nervous now, and then there it was. It had been sitting there plain as day in the block lettering the Imperials favored–in fact, he'd probably already skimmed it a time or two–but he'd not registered it. No, he'd not *wanted* to. He stared hard at the display, then leaned in closer, hoping as he did so that the words could unblur and he could find he'd been wrong.

VALIANT, he read. He read it again. VALIANT. His field of vision narrowed as his heart pounded in his ears. He swallowed, eager–desperate–to keep himself from panting.

He read it again. *Valiant*. His stomach dropped, and right behind that came a deep conviction: *No. No. I can't.*

His first cogent thought was to jump up from the table and dash. Nothing sounded so good as running away from the whole thing as fast as possible. But sense flashed amid his panic, reminded him of the coterie of guards, Besadii and Desilijic alike, who stood just outside the doorway. Even if he managed to get past them, he knew none would hesitate to shoot him in the back. If he somehow managed to get out of the back rooms of the casino, he had a whole sector to cross, and how to get to his ship in the Hutts' bay? He gulped, trying to drop his chin and focus.

Rho must have picked up on Han's fluster. He looked the younger man over for a beat, frowning part in confusion and part in concern. "What is it?"

Han met his gaze only fleetingly, then held his breath for a beat to get his pulse to stop hammering. No one could know; he couldn't let them see. He needed to keep control, to veil. Keep a straight face. Keep cool. Walk out of here, get to the ship, then be gone. Soon as he was out of tractor beam range, punch it, hyperspace to *anywhere*, just not here, Nar Shaddaa and the Hutts and the Empire be damned.

He licked his lips, his breath coming out in tremors. *Slow down*, he coached. Easy.

"Thought I read the name of someone I knew." His chin wrinkled in a tight, forced frown. "Different guy."

He swallowed again, this one effective at feeling like it righted him. He turned his attention back up to the screen–reading, against his will–those block letters one more time, then switched to a different screen. In his head, he started to play out how he'd make his move back toward the hangar.

The *swish* of the door at his back spooked him more than he anticipated. On his left and right, the *kajidii* envoys reassumed their positions, and Han read a tenuous resolve on their faces.

"Captain Metis," Deino started, "do you believe you can pull together a defensive force?"

Rho chewed on the question first, his jaw clenching against its bite. Wordlessly, he nodded.

Deino inclined toward Ganar Tos. "*Kajidii* Desilijic and Besadii will be in your debt. Pull together a force and push back these invaders, and all who participate will receive additional favor."

Han read the immediate scrutiny in Rho's face, and he caught the slight tilt in Deino's chin as she saw it, too. "No pay?" Rho questioned. "You want me to pull smugglers together into a fighting force with no pay?"

Tos harumphed. "Everyone stands to win if Nar Shaddaa, and

Hutt Space in general, can keep its neutrality and independence. Surely, smugglers will fight for that." His face twisted in some self-satisfied grin. "Don't you all do that regularly anyway–fight back the Imperials for personal gain?"

Taunting, Han grimaced, unable to hide his scowl. What a time to twist the knife.

"In addition to favor," Deino continued, speaking up to reestablish diplomacy, "you all will have first rights to whatever scrap, booty, or materiel you can scavenge and whatever ransom you can garner."

"Pirates," Rho answered flatly. "You're gonna make us be pirates?"

Deino leaned forward. "Would you rather *be* pirates or rot in an Imperial prison when they capture you for smuggling and *call* you a pirate?"

The Old Man held her gaze. "I'd like to talk to your bosses myself. See if we can work something out that's more tangible." He let the word hang in the air, but before either majordomo could interrupt him, he continued. "Smugglers are not soldiers. They avoid conflict, not run toward. I'm gonna have to have a really good reason to ask them to stay here and face something head on than leave for clearer skies and greener pastures."

Deino and Tos exchanged glances first, then the former inclined her head. "We can arrange a meeting. How many participants do you suppose you'll need?"

Rho gestured across the table. "Solo here says a hundred vessels."

"Well, consider it ninety-nine," she pronounced, then turned to Han, any warmth she'd managed for Rho draining from her face. "Solo. I was prepared to string you up for skimming off the top." Before Han could interject, she smiled with a dark menace. "I told you I'd remember. Looks like I'll get to keep that in my back pocket."

"You will help Captain Metis and the others in their endeavor," Ganar Tos continued. "Whatever he needs. I imagine that

will include direct involvement." The Zisian paused, seemingly savoring the writhing his sentencing had produced in the Corellian. "In exchange, *kajidic* Besadii will not execute you for your betrayal. We will remove the bounty on your head."

Han felt his mouth go dry, ignoring the torrent of screaming in his head that damn near drowned out the rest of the room. He knew better than to argue. He'd say yes to them, play along, be grateful, and then, the first opening he saw–

"And, additionally," Deino crooned, "because of your behavior on Ylesia, there will be some *limitations* placed on you as insurance."

* * *

When he closed his eyes, even when he blinked, he could still see the route that took him from the hangar entry at the front of the ship all the way down into her belly to crew quarters and the med ward and the mess hall. He'd bunked with three other pilots–Vax, Hoorie, and Schooner. Fresh bedding had arrived every week, there waiting for him when he returned from drills: a flat sheet, a fitted sheet, and an all-too-thin blanket that barely insulated against the ship's relentless chill. For a long time, he'd assumed there was something faulty with the *Valiant's* life support systems, that the frigid air seeping into every hangar and hallway was some engineering defect no one cared to fix. No, he learned later; that was simply how the Imps worked.

He'd liked his bunkmates well enough, but his closest companion was Eden. He bunked two levels below him and flew in a different squadron. They always met in the mess hall, comparing notes about main deck officers and baiting each other on who on staff to flirt with next. Eden had graduated the Academy with him–Han could suddenly vividly remember shaking his hand as they found each other after the ceremony, laughing and overjoyed. When Han's request for reassignment was accepted only a year into service, Eden had walked him down to the bay for his departure. Han had promised

he would stay in touch. He'd forgotten.

The lift shuttered as it came to the ground floor of the Spacebarn.

Jolted back to full consciousness, Han busied himself with the locking mechanism, then stared long at the corridor ahead of him. In the distance, the light over Mako's bay entrance glowed blue. He'd already walked all the way from the Entertainment District; all he had to do was make it another 200 meters. Why did it feel so far?

His feet dragged, which was a welcome change from the floating sensation he'd experienced upon leaving the Chance Castle, the bizarre feeling of being not quite in his body, his consciousness hovering above him in some staticky lightning. The heaviness he now felt in his body meant he was coming back down to his senses, more in control of his thoughts and his limbs. Their weight he would get accustomed to; he'd find strength again. Resolve. But first, perhaps, he required an unburdening, a thoughtful placing down of the load on his shoulders.

He heard the shuffling inside Mako's bay before he even rounded the corner, the metal *clang* of riffling through a tool box. Coming into the hangar entrance, he paused and peered in just in time to watch Mako turn his toolbox upside down and spill its contents across the floor as he mumbled a curse under his breath. His hands filtered through the mess, tools spinning and tumbling as they were tossed aside, until his eye apparently caught its desire and he delicately pinched a tiny screwdriver from the pile.

Spince was grinning to himself as he stood upright when Han's silhouette in the doorway caught his attention. Mako laughed, holding up the screwdriver. "Can never find the damn things," he explained.

Han couldn't find it in him to return the grin. Couldn't even lob a sarcastic jab. Instead, tight lipped, he shifted his weight.

Mako tucked the tool away and then righted his toolbox, crouching to clean up the mess. "I hadn't heard you come in. What's up?"

Han couldn't answer. He needed to sit first. Maybe sitting would let enough air fill his lungs to speak. He shuffled over to a nearby crate and managed to lift a hip onto it, then with concerted effort, hoisted up the other. For a fleeting second, he felt the relief in his feet, and then registered how much his spine compressed, how difficult it felt to hold up his head, keep his eyes open. Not in a sleepy way exactly. Just…spent.

The toolbox refilled–albeit a jumbled heap–Mako studied Han in silence, his hand busy untwisting the setting on a wrench. "Bad?"

Despite the weight on his chest, Han managed a sigh. "Worse than bad." *Worse*. Yeah, he reasoned faintly, it was hard to think how much worse it could be. Shitty to choke, even shittier to choke on a noose you made yourself, and *then* had walked into. "I fucked up."

"How much?"

Numbly, Han struggled to figure out how to put it. With a painful sneer, he adjusted his legs first before he answered. "You remember, at the Academy, right after that thing with the Mascot Moon, how dead the air was after they radioed you to hold your position?"

Mako had gone still, whether purely at the mention of the accident or the comparison, Han wasn't sure. "Yeah," the older man eventually croaked.

Han tried to shrug. Were his shoulders always this difficult to move? "Worse than that."

Mako's lips puckered into a pout while he thought. Finally, he winced, eyeing Han sideways. "Big stakeholders?" In response, Han could only offer silence, a muteness only partially rooted in torpor. Mako read his withholding. "Don't wanna tell me? Hm, that tells me a lot."

Han chewed the inside of his cheek, considering. He wanted–maybe, regretfully, *needed*–Spince's input, but how to ask him without telling him? At the same time…the way Rho had looked, how sullen, downtrodden, how strained at the idea of having to pull

together a hundred–*ninety-nine*, he bitterly recalled–volunteers, Mako was sure to find out anyway…

"Listen, you didn't hear this from me. Act surprised if anyone else approaches you about it. *Especially* Rho." Han paused, his brows raised as he waited for a look of confirmation on the older man's face. Having received the tight nod he expected from Mako, Han exhaled, weary. "Truce between the Hutts and the Imperials has fallen through. The Imps are coming here."

Immediately, those silvery brows went up in humored surprise. "And why are you so bent out of shape about it?"

Han shrugged limply, his eyes trailing the ground. "I got roped in."

"How?" Mako asked, his nearly white irises disappearing in his scrutinizing squint.

A grimace first, then an almost mumbled answer. "I have a tab open with Aruk of Besadii."

Mako's eyes widened, then he gave a long whistle. "That's quite the rope."

Han sucked in a breath. He didn't feel naive too often. He felt stupid now. He should have known the Hutts would not squander any kind of advantage. They didn't wield power so thoroughly by accident.

"How big of an affront?" Spince continued.

Too big, Han mused first. "An old Praetor, four Neb Bs, and six light cruisers."

Mako's brow furrowed asymmetrically. "You say that like you know for sure."

"Hutts managed to get a hold of the plans," Han answered. "Still don't know how the hell they managed it, but they called in Rho, and he called in me to verify."

Mako toyed with that information for a bit. "That's it?"

"That's *it*?" Han volleyed with strain.

"I'm just sayin', all things considered, that's small," the older man returned. "I've seen larger retinues used for delivering ambassadors."

Hearing Spince make the same assessment actually eased some of the pressure on his chest. Han perked up slightly. "I wanted to ask you about that. They're bringing a moff."

This made Mako tilt his head and crack a sidewise smile. He closed the distance. "There's a moff at the helm? Who?"

For a beat, Han couldn't remember. Blankly, he searched his memory, and when that failed, closed his eyes and tried to relive the moment across the table from Rho, digging through the data file. Though he wanted to try and reimagine the holo readout, his brain kept skipping the blue words of the field and instead focused on the image beyond it: the Old Man crumpled in his seat, head in his hand. Defeated. The sight did tug at his heart.

It came to him! "Greenlax!" he shouted, yelling it like he might forget again.

"Greenlax," Mako repeated. He paced for a bit, dirtied thumb between his teeth as he thought. Abruptly, he stopped, revelation lighting up his face. "I do know that name. I can remember the old murra ranting to me about him. Something about him being a…" he paused as he tried to get the words and the impression right, "'runny nosed interloper who wouldn't be happy until he licked Vader's colon from the inside.'"

Han stifled his surprise; Mako spoke of his father little, though when he did, he proved consistently capable of imitating both his tone and his colorful turn of phrase. Han had only met the man once–at a family event during the Academy. The elder Spince had proven to be of both noble stock and surly temperament, though he had been warm and inviting to Han, who had no family of his own to attend the function. Even at such a pleasant occasion and the older Spince striving to maintain decorum, the strain between father and son had been evident.

"You think this is a political stunt?" Han offered as redirection.

Mako huffed out a laugh. "'When all signs point to trouble…'"

Han finished the Rhoism. "'...don't waste your time thinking anything else.' But to what end?"

Spince leaned to one side, arms crossed, brainstorming. "If I had to hazard a guess? They're sending a pretty small outfit here. You think to blockade?"

Han had to scratch at the corner of his mouth before he could say it. "Not think–know."

"Okay, to blockade the hyperspace entrance. And they've got a Praetor? She must be beat to shit." He paused, deliberating for a beat. "Either they're trying to throw away the Praetor or they're getting rid of the moff. Hell, maybe even both? Greenlax is a suck up and social climber. Old blood and old money, but not really liked. Throw his ass on an outdated ship and tell him to face off the Hutts and the trash will take itself out."

This made Han start. "You think the Imps want the–" he almost said *Valiant*, but managed to catch himself with only a slight trip in his cadence, "–Praetor taken out?"

Mako scoffed. "Not necessarily. I mean, it'll be political suicide for Greenlax if the Hutts don't blink. But the Praetor? Those ships should have all been decommissioned five, ten years ago. Any additional damage she takes would be enough to justify finally putting her out of her misery. And besides, *who's* taking the Praetor out?"

At that, Han sighed again, resigned.

Mako squinted. "*No*," he insisted, unbelieving, but Han's heavy head made the truth apparent. "*That's* why they called Rho?"

"If anyone can pull enough people together, it's him." Han lifted eyes again. "Remember, you *did not* hear this from me."

"Yeah, yeah," Mako half-answered, lost in his own thoughts. "So, Rho's gonna put together a resistance?"

Han shrugged. "He said he's gonna try. Said it'd take pulling on all his contacts and all his favors, but he's gonna try." When Spince's wheels looked like they started spinning even faster at Han's confirmation, the younger man frowned, cautious. "Why?"

"I was just thinking…" His voice trailed off and he laughed at himself. His eyebrows raised, that mischievous glint in his eye. "What if we scuttled the fleet?"

Han gaped–both at Mako's implied volunteering and his idea. "You want to take on a Praetor?!"

Mako's chin wrinkled. "Why not? We're gonna go out there and risk our asses anyway–why not get somethin' for it? Something *big*!" He snorted a laugh. "Do you know what any one of us could do with machinery like that, Han? The Hutts don't even have anything that big."

"I don't wanna piss off the Imps any more than we might be already," was the best rebuttal Han could offer.

"No, that's *reason* to take that ship outta their hands. I mean, c'mon, we chase 'em off, and then what? They'll just be back again with something bigger and stronger. We need a deterrent. Insurance."

Han's brain went loud with static again, his body suddenly no longer belonging to him, a deafening ringing in his ears. His consciousness had managed to uncouple, to float up, away…

Scuttling the *Valiant*–that would mean so much more firepower, so much more risk, than he'd envisioned up until now. The Neb Bs and the Gozantis and their entire TIE outfit would need to be destroyed–he'd already made peace with that–but the *Valiant* would need to be crippled enough to get boarded. To force surrender, capture. She'd not bow easily. Everyone–gunners, TIE fighters, bombers, marines, command, cooks–would fight to the last man. That's what they were trained for, to always protect their home base, to the death if need be. And again, the faces of Vax, Hoorie, Schooner–Eden–flashed in front of him.

Han cleared his throat. "I don't…I don't think Rho could ever drum up the kind of fire power for that," he countered, his voice low. "She's not at a hundred percent, but she can still pack a punch. We'd turn ourselves into space glitter if we go in there attempting to overtake her."

Mako winced, then perked back up. "Maybe we invite Drea to the party?"

"Then you'd have to promise her the Praetor," Han argued. "She won't risk her skin for less than that. She's a pirate, Mako, not a martyr."

"Well, maybe that's worth it! Maybe we involve her, promise her a capital ship, and then she can keep her and her friends' noses out of our business in exchange."

"I just don't think it's a good idea," Han barked back, his voice raised as he leered slightly at Mako. "We could probably put up a solid front against her, but if the Praetor wants to go, we should let her. Besides, I don't trust Renthal. I don't want her getting her hands on something more deadly than *Renthal's Fist* already is."

Mako went quiet. Pouting. He never had been very good at being told no. "I'll run it past Rho."

Han scoffed. "Fine! Run it past Rho–I'll be shocked if he says anything different." Han receded then, both wanting to move on to something different and also painfully aware of how mired in all of it he was. Seeking some kind of escape, he lifted his chin and observed a ray of sunlight that glimmered near the ceiling, its radiance cutting through the dusty air in fractured beams. The nearing of noon. The moon coming into wakefulness. Today, the spreading of the sunshine came with the spreading of the news.

Frustrated, he grimaced, then dropped his gaze and took in Mako still silently pondering. "So you think you'll join?"

Spince stirred from his thoughts, lifted his icy-blue eyes in mild surprise at the question, which he quickly covered with a wry grin and impish twinkle. "Yeah. It's been kinda boring lately."

Han's next thought almost jumped out of his mouth, but he held it for a bit, debating if it needed asking. He *was* curious. "No part of it would feel like revenge to you?" he asked quietly, probing.

Mako chortled. "Revenge? 'Cause they booted me out of the Academy? I don't give a shit about that."

Han shrugged. "Not even a little?"

The older Corellian mused over that question for a minute, still grinning. "Well, I won't deny it tickles my dick a little whenever those stuffed shirts get theirs."

The answer didn't help the way Han hoped it might. Maybe, he wondered, maybe he'd hoped he'd hear from Mako some kind of hesitation or guilt…something that would make the knot in his stomach make sense. He'd fired on Imperials before. Destroyed a TIE fighter a couple months ago without any hesitation or regret. It *should* feel the same–he *wanted* it to feel the same…but it didn't.

"You having a hard time with it?"

Han lifted from his thoughts to see Mako peering at him, a deep look that Han struggled to evade. "Not really enthused at having my arm twisted."

Spince was quiet for a few more beats, continuing to study Han, until his eyes narrowed. "You don't serve the Empire anymore," Mako said quietly.

"I know that!" Han snipped back. "It's not that! It's…" And for a second, he thought of telling him, of sharing the full truth, of having something else carry with him the burden of the knowledge.

Immediately, he backed off. No one could know. If they knew, they'd start suspecting him, and he meant to lay low, to not give anyone reason to doubt his commitment. If he was going to find a way out of this, to slip away, he needed a screen, and that screen was compliance.

"It's…what?" Mako prompted, eyebrows raised anticipatorily.

Han inhaled, pushing against the vice at his ribs to buy time for an answer. "It's–"

"It's sentiment," Mako answered, then snorted, half amused, half mocking. "I thought that piece of shit bounty hunter you ran with beat that out of you."

Han grimaced to be reminded. "He tried," he returned tightly. "Mostly succeeded. Look, this ain't about–"

Mako beat Han to it. "This is about you not wanting to take 'em all out. You wore the uniform, and it makes you a little queasy to

think about having to face ‘em in a line and fire. Doesn’t have quite the same feel to it as shooting behind you after dodging a customs check.”

Han went still, the same way a veral might once it had spotted a predator–stay still, so they can’t see you.

Mako continued. “I mean, I get it…sort of. Look, I know you already know this, buddy, but ask yourself: do you think they’d think twice about giving an order to shoot you down? Do you think they’ll look at that little red vessel and wonder about the life of the pilot at the helm, the gunner, any additional crew? Even if they *knew* that it was you, do you think any of them would hesitate to fire?”

Reflexively, Han opened his mouth to protest. When he pictured a TIE fighter pilot studying what info ran across their scanners, he pictured Eden. The man had a quick smile, a playfulness about him that made him easy to get along with. Talented pilot, too; they all had been. Eden would hesitate, right? Right?! *Sure*, he heard a distance voice reassure, Eden might. Someone else wouldn’t.

Han’s throat tightened. “No,” he mustered.

“No,” Mako spat, then started to grin sardonically. “They don’t give two shits about you Han, or me, or anybody else. You’ve already crossed the line. You’re a betrayer, far as they’re concerned, a problem to be eradicated before you poison the rest of the system. ‘Cause that’s all that matters to them, and I know you know that, that’s what they get everybody in that damn place to do, to put everything else that fucking makes a lick of sense and swallow it down and instead do everything they’re told, and they *do it*, because they still wholeheartedly believe in the Empire. The system.” Mako took a step back, looking long down his nose at Han. “Don’t think about them, ‘cause they sure ain’t thinking about you.”

As Han’s head fell in thought, Mako crossed back to the toolbox and dropped the little screwdriver back in it. “Besides,” he waxed, maybe a tinge too confident, “if you have Aruk breathing down your neck about who knows what, then it seems like you don’t have much of a choice. The Hutts weren’t really *asking* for your help, and

you can't afford to lose." With only a second of pause, Mako's expression melted into geniality. "I'm hungry–you wanna do breakfast?"

Food seemed like the strangest thing to even consider. Dazed, Han shook his head no.

"Well, I'm starved, so…get the hell out of my bay." Mako then gestured for Han to leave, his arm outstretched as he waited for the younger Corellian to find his footing again and plod forward back out into the hangar walkway. "Wonder if I'll run into Rho if I go to Veno's," he mumbled, mostly to himself, then tittered. "It'd be good if I could get to Rho's ear early."

Han, still feeling the tingle in his legs, winced as stiffness painfully gave way to ambling. He was slow to make the few steps back to the bay entrance, though he could see Mako filing in behind him.

"Well, I'm sure *we'll* talk soon," Mako laughed as he quickened his pace a bit to meet Han face-to-face. "Suppose you got plenty of work to do on the…" he started, then his voice trailed off as his head turned to look into Bay 7 and did not see the red *Starmite* on her spindly legs.

He spun around, eyes wild. "Where's the 'Suub?!"

Hesitant, mournful, almost sheepish, Han found the strength to gesture over his shoulder with his thumb. Westward–toward the Hutt Palace.

Realization manifested on Mako's face, a widening of those ice-blue eyes that just as quickly crinkled into sharp humor. "Man, you *are* fucked."